Bangladesh Studies

Bangladesh – an Overview

Outline

- Brief History of Bengal – Periodization, Empires/Kingdoms/Ruler
- Land, People and Demography
- Education, Ethnicity and Languages
- Culture and Diversity(A detailed discussion will be discussed in the next chapter)
- Trivia and Questions
- Further Reading

Bangladesh: Brief History

- Civilizational footprints in the eastern part of Bengal (now known as Bangladesh) date back to the ancient period (Lalmai-Comilla, Mahastangoar, Wari Bateshwar)
- Geographically, historically, and culturally, Bangladesh forms the larger and more populous part of Bengal, the remainder of which creates the neighboring Indian state of West Bengal.
- From 1947 to 1971, Bangladesh was a province of Pakistan. As such, its official designation was changed from East Bengal to East Pakistan in 1955. On March 26, 1971, leaders of East Pakistan declared the province independent as Bangladesh (Bengali for “land of the Bengalis”), and
- Its independence was assured on December 16, 1971, when Pakistani troops in the region surrendered to a joint force of Bangladeshi and Indian troops.
- Bangladesh is the only country in the world born out of an ethno-linguistic struggle in 1971, at the height of the Cold War.

Periodization of the History of Bangladesh

The history of Bengal is often divided into three broad Periods:

- **Ancient Bengal (up to 1204)**
  Includes Gangaridai, Maurya, Gupta, Gauda (Shahnka), Palas empire/kingdoms.

- Medieval Bengal (1204-1757)
  Includes Muslim Conquest and Rule

- Modern Bengal (1757-)
  Includes Colonial (British) and “Pakistani” Period

Bangladesh: Brief History

Period	Dynasty/ Empire	Remarks /Evidence
Later half of 4th century BC	**Gangaridai**	Precise boundary is unknown. Presumed to be located to the east of the ancient Ganges & the Bhagirathi river. Some historians connects the archeological evidence (i.e. two types of silver punch-marked coins, pit dwelling etc.) of Wari Bateshwar with the Mahajanapada of Gangaridai
321-185 BC	**Maurya**	The Maurya political suzerainty was confined to the north No direct evidence to prove that Bengal was a part of Bengal only. Direct evidence of Maurya occupation of north Bengal and indirect evidence of Maurya influence in other areas.
1st & 2nd Century A.D.	**Kushans (may be)**	The Kushana empire (discovery of the Kushana coins).
331-650 A.D.	**Gupta (part of)**	Evidence of direct Gupta suzerainty in north Bengal. But East Bengal occasionally paid tribute.
600-650 A.D.	**Gauda (of Shasanka)**	East Bengal was not a part of the Gauda empire as evidenced by the existence of Bhadra dynasty.

Source: Akbar Ali Khan (2021). *Discovery of Bangladesh- Exploration into Dynamics of a Hidden Nation, University Press Limited. pp.9-10*

Bangladesh: Brief History

Period	Dynasty/ Empire	Remarks /Evidence
650-750 A.D.	**Matsyanyayam (Period of Anarchy)**	Independent Khadaga dynasty ruled East Bengal (650-700 A.D.)
750-1162 AD.	**The Palas**	Primarily confined to Bihar and certain areas of north Bengal. Except a short period in the 11th century (1043-1075 AD), it remained outside the orbit of the Pala empire. All the inscriptions of early Pala rulers were issued from Bihar and lands granted by them were located in Bihar/parts of northern Bengal.
1160- 1206 AD.	**The Senas (The whole of Bengal).**	The Sena kingdom was based in Bengal and was not a north-India-based empire.
1204-1757	**Delhi based Muslim empires**	Out of about 550 years of Muslim rule, Bengal was effectively ruled for 200 years by Delhi-based all-India empires. For about 350 years, Bengal remained effectively independent.
1757 -1947	**British (Colonial) rule by East India Company and direct British Crown rule**	The colonial rule (primarily by the British) started with the East India company winning in Battle of Plassey and Battle of Buxar. Company's initial influence was followed by direct British Crown rule (the British Raj) from 1858. Bengal was partitioned by the British in 1905 (by Lord Curzon) and later the partition was annulled in 1911, the year that the capital was shifted from Calcutta (now Kolkata) to Delhi.
1947-1971	**Pakistani Period**	

Source: Akbar Ali Khan [2021]. *Discovery of Bangladesh- Exploration into Dynamics of a Hidden Nation*. University Press Limited. pp 9-10

BANGLADESH: LAND & PEOPLE

Official Name: People's Republic of Bangladesh (Gana Prajatantri Bangladesh)



Location: Southern Asia - NE part of Indian subcontinent. Bangladesh extends from 20°34'N to 26°38'N latitude and from 88°01'E to 92°41'E longitude

Land Area: 147,570 sq km.

Population: Around 17 crore (One of the most densely populated countries - 1,265 per Km2/8th)



Boundaries:

- West Bengal (India) on the **west**; W. Bengal, Assam and Meghalaya (India) on the **north**; Assam, Tripura and Mizoram in the **East;** Myanmar on the **Southeast**
- Bay of Bengal on the **South** – opening to the world

Land Border Length: Around 4,246 km (93.9% shared with India, 6% with Myanmar). Provides the only relatively easy land between the eastern and western parts of Asia

BANGLADESH: LAND & PEOPLE

- **Big Delta and a Riverine country** - collects the alluviation coming with the waters from the rivers originated from the Himalayas.– Floodplains of Ganges, Brahmaputra & Meghna

- **Upland** - Baridra Tract (between Ganges & Brahmaputra-Jamuna) & Madhuur Tract (Bhawal Garh)

- **Hills & Valleys (1/8th) in Eastern Part (CTG, CHT)** – links ancient Bengal with Arakan Kingdoms.

- **Tropical Climate (Tropic of Cancer bisects the country)** – multiple harvesting & varieties of crops



Trivia: *What is the tropic of cancer (কর্কটক্রান্তি রেখা)?*

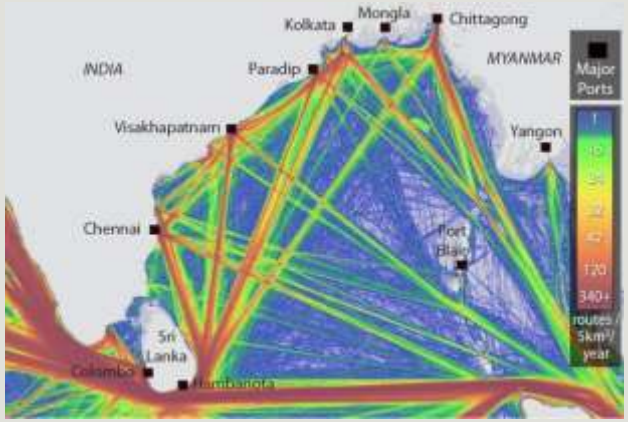
BANGLADESH: LAND & PEOPLE

- **Territorial Water & EEZ:** 12 nm (22.22 km) and the area of the high seas extending to 200 nm (370.40 km) from the baselines constitutes the **Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ).**

- **Large Coastline (1,400 km):** opening to the World Sea

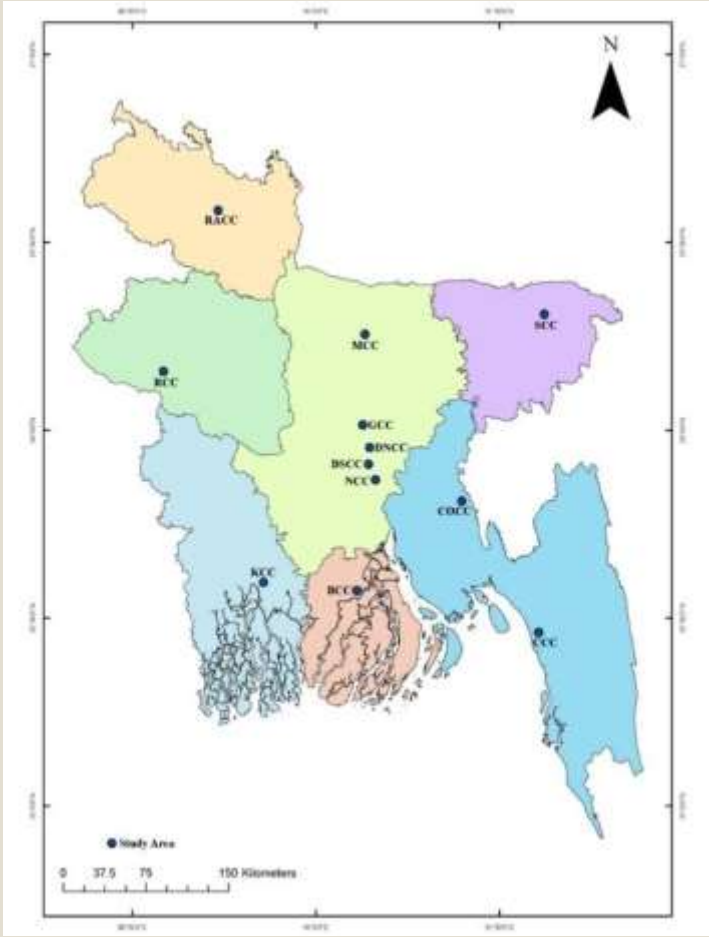
- Line of Communication (SLOCs)





BANGLADESH: ADMINISTRATIVE STRUCTURE

- **Eight Principal Administrative units (Divisions):** Barishal, Chattogram, Dhaka, Mymensingh, Khulna, Rajshahi, Rangpur and Sylhet.
- 64 Districts (Zilas) in Eight divisions
- 495 upazilas(sub-districts) and 652 thanas.
- **12 City corporation(12):** Dhaka South, Dhaka North, Chattogram, Khulna, Sylhet, Rajshahi, Barishal, Rangpur, Cumilla, Narayanganj, Mymensingh, and Gazipur.
- City mayors are elected through direct voting of the citizens for a span of five years.



BANGLADESH: ADMINISTRATIVE STRUCTURE

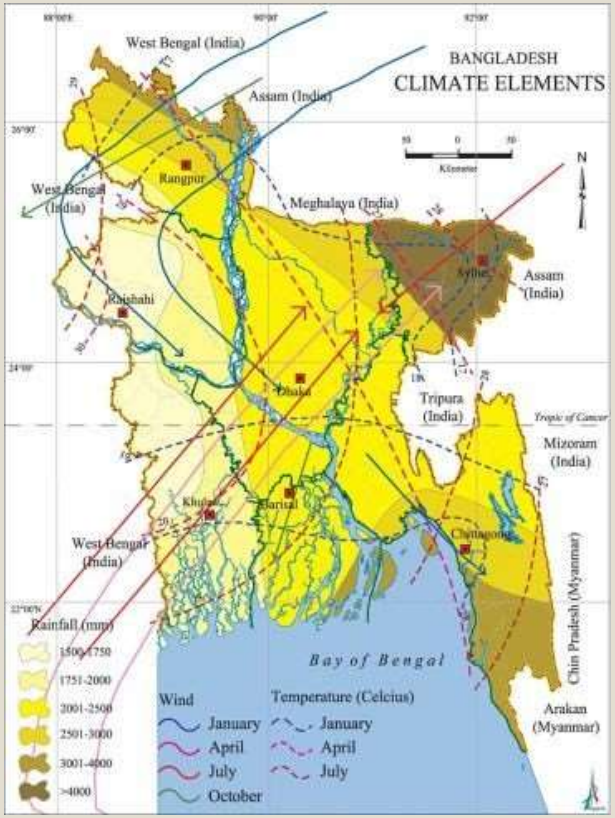
- **Municipal Corporations (also known as Paurasabha)** are the local governing bodies of the cities and towns. There are **330** such municipal corporations in eight divisions of Bangladesh.

- Union Councils **(or Union Parishads or Unions-4,554)** are the smallest rural administrative and local government units in Bangladesh. Union Parishads are formed under the **Local Government (Union Parishads) Act, 2009.**

Source: http://bdlaws.minlaw.gov.bd/act-1027.html

Bangladesh: Climate

- Subtropical monsoon climate characterized by wide seasonal variations in rainfall, moderately warm temperatures, and high humidity. and fairly marked seasonal variations.
- The most striking feature of its climate is the reversal of the wind circulation between summer and winter, which is an integral part of the circulation system of the South Asian subcontinent.
- From the climatic point of view, three distinct seasons can be recognized in Bangladesh



Cool Dry Season: Nov – Feb
Pre-Monsoon Hot Season: March – May
Rainy Monsoon season: June- Oct

The month of March is considered the spring season, and the period from mid-October through mid-November is called the Autumn season.

For more: https://en.banglapedia.org/index.php?title=Climate

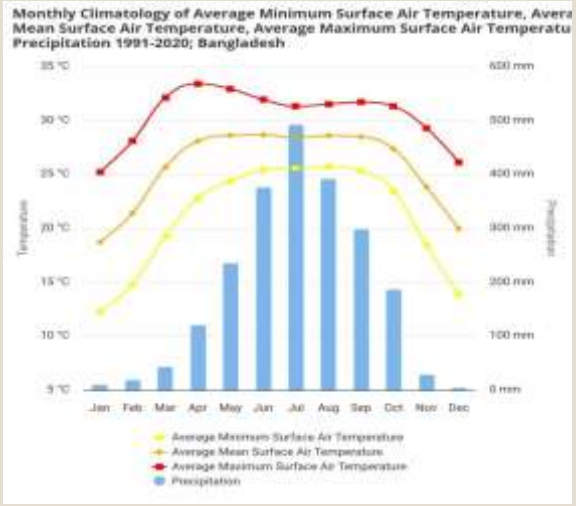
Bangladesh: Climate

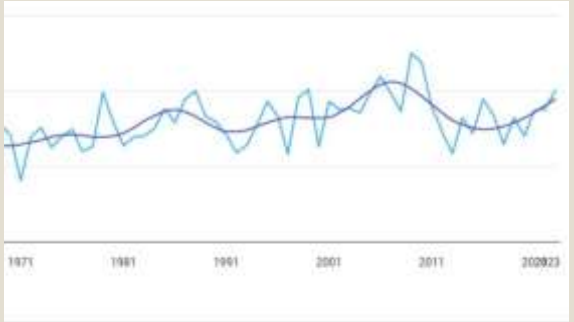
- **Range of Max Summer Temp:** 32°C - 40°C.
- **April:** Warmest month in most parts
- **January:** Coldest month (average temperature for most of the country is 10°C during this month)

The *average lowest temperature shows a declining trend*, while the *maximum temperature shows an increasing trend.*

A very wet country, receiving on ***average about 2,200 mm of rainfall/year.*** Most regions receive at least 1,500 mm, and others, such as in the NE (Northern border of India) border regions, receive as much as 5,000 mm of rainfall/year (Chera punji)

Floods, tropical cyclones, tornadoes, and tidal bores affect the country almost every year. Bangladesh is also affected by major cyclones--**on average 16 times a decade.**

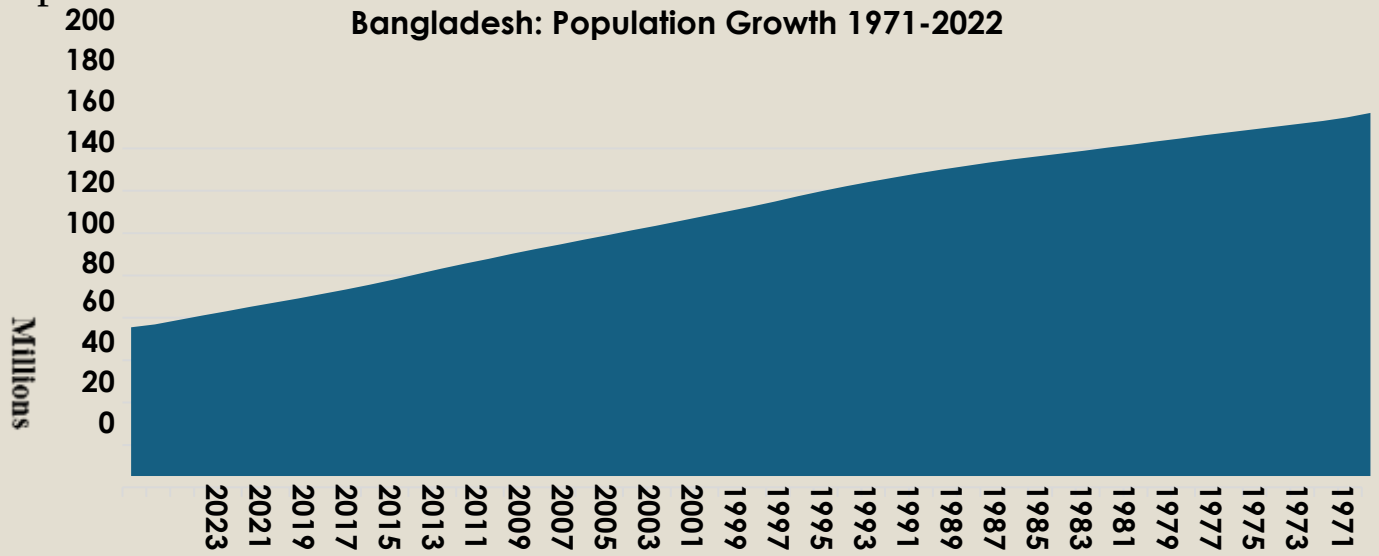




https://climateknowledgeportal.worldbank.org/country/bangladesh/climate-data-historical#:~:text=Bangladesh%20is%20a%20very%20wet,mm%20of%20rainfall%20per%20year.

Bangladesh: Demographics

- Bangladesh has a high population growth rate. It is the eighth most populated country in the world.
- In the mid-eighties, the government began promoting birth control to slow population growth, but with limited success.
- The government has gained considerable success in preventing the spread of many childhood diseases through an effective nationwide immunization policy. However, many are landless or forced to inhabit hazardous floodplains, with the consequence of rampant water-borne disease.



Data Source: *https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SP.POP.TOTL?locations=BD*

Bangladesh: Demographics

- Apart from some small countries (like Singapore & Bahrain), Bangladesh is one of the **most densely populated countries in the world (8th).**
- Bangladesh is ethnically homogenous, with **Bengalis comprising 98%** of the population, the rest belonging to the non-Bengali and tribal people like Chakma, Marma, Mundas, Garos, Oraons, Tripura, Shantals, Manipuri, Mru, Khashia, and Bihari.

- A substantial number of non-Bengali tribal groups inhabit the Chittagong Hill Tracts in the Southeast and the Northern regions, including parts of the districts of Mymensingh, Sylhet, and Rangpur.
- Most **Bangladeshis (88-89%) are Muslims**. **Hindus constitute (9-10%)**. There are also a small number of Buddhists, Christians, and Animists.

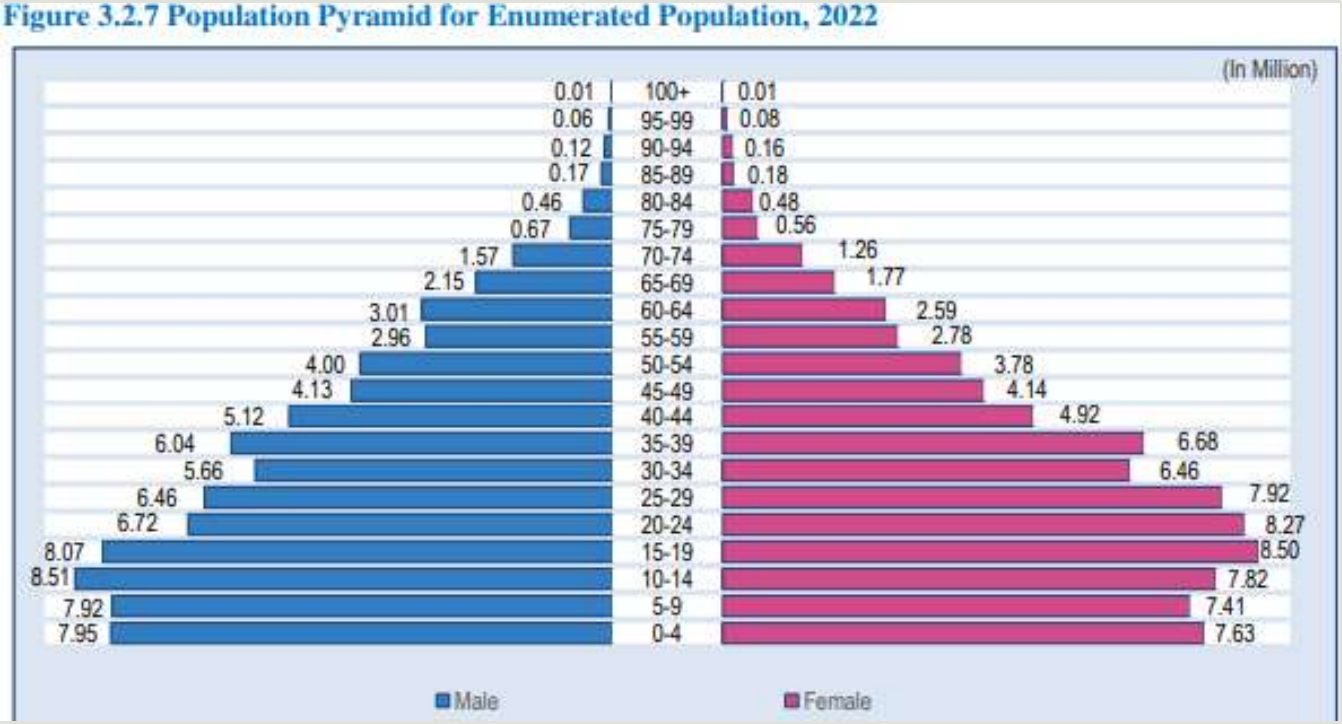
Demographics

Areas	Rate/ Numbers	Sources
Total population	174.7 (Male 49.51; Female, 50.49)	www.unfpa.org, BBS 2022
Total fertility rate	1.9 per women	www.unfpa.org
Total fertility rate	2.10 per women	BBS, 2023
Total fertility rate	2.3 per women	BDSH, 2022
Maternal Mortality Ratio (deaths per 100,000 live births)	123 (2022)	www.unfpa.org
Population growth rate	1.22%	www.worldomete rs.info
Child Mortality Rate	25 per thousand childbirth	BBS, 2022
Under-five mortality rate	28.8 deaths per 1000 live births	www.unicef.org
Life expectancy at birth (Years) - 2022	Female: 76.012 Male: 71.514 All: 73.698	https://hdr.undp.org/d ata-center/specific-country-data#/countries/BGD

Demographics

Labour force participation rate, female (% ages 15 and older) (2022)	39.15%
CO2 Emissions per capita (production) (tonnes) (2022)	0.583152966
Material footprint per capita (tonnes) (2022)	4.6457
Planetary pressures-adjusted Human Development Index (value) (2022)	0.656

Demographic Dividend: Youth Bulge



- Bangladesh enjoys a demographic dividend – unlike many advanced countries having an aging population, a large percentage of the Bangladeshi population is young.
- Bangladesh's population pyramid reveals her "demographic dividend.".
- Out of the total male, young population aged 10-14 years is the highest (8.51 million), followed by the age group 15-19 years (8.07 mil). Out of the total female population, the age of 15-19 is the highest (8.50 mil), followed by the age of 20-24 years (8.27 mil).

Bangladesh: Economy

- When it first became a country, in 1971, Bangladesh was incredibly poor. Things have moved. Bangladesh now has an average growth rate of 6% in 2023, which shows a declining trend, as it was 7.1% in 2022.

- Bangladesh has made remarkable progress in reducing poverty, supported by sustained economic growth. Based on the international poverty line of $1.90 (using purchasing power parity exchange rate) a day, it reduced poverty from 44.2 percent in 1991 to 14.8 percent in 2016/17.

- Bangladesh's poverty rate came down to 21.8% while the poverty rate, as per the lower poverty line or people living in extreme poverty, came down to 11.3% in 2018, according to the latest data of the Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics (BBS).

- Population living below the national poverty line dropped to 18.7% in 2022 (BBS, 2022), which was 24.3% in 2016 from 31.5% in 2010. (ADB)

- Rapid growth enabled Bangladesh to reach the lower-middle-income country status in 2015. In 2018, Bangladesh fulfilled all three eligibility criteria for graduation from the UN's Least Developed Countries (LDC) list for the first time and is on track for graduation in 2024.

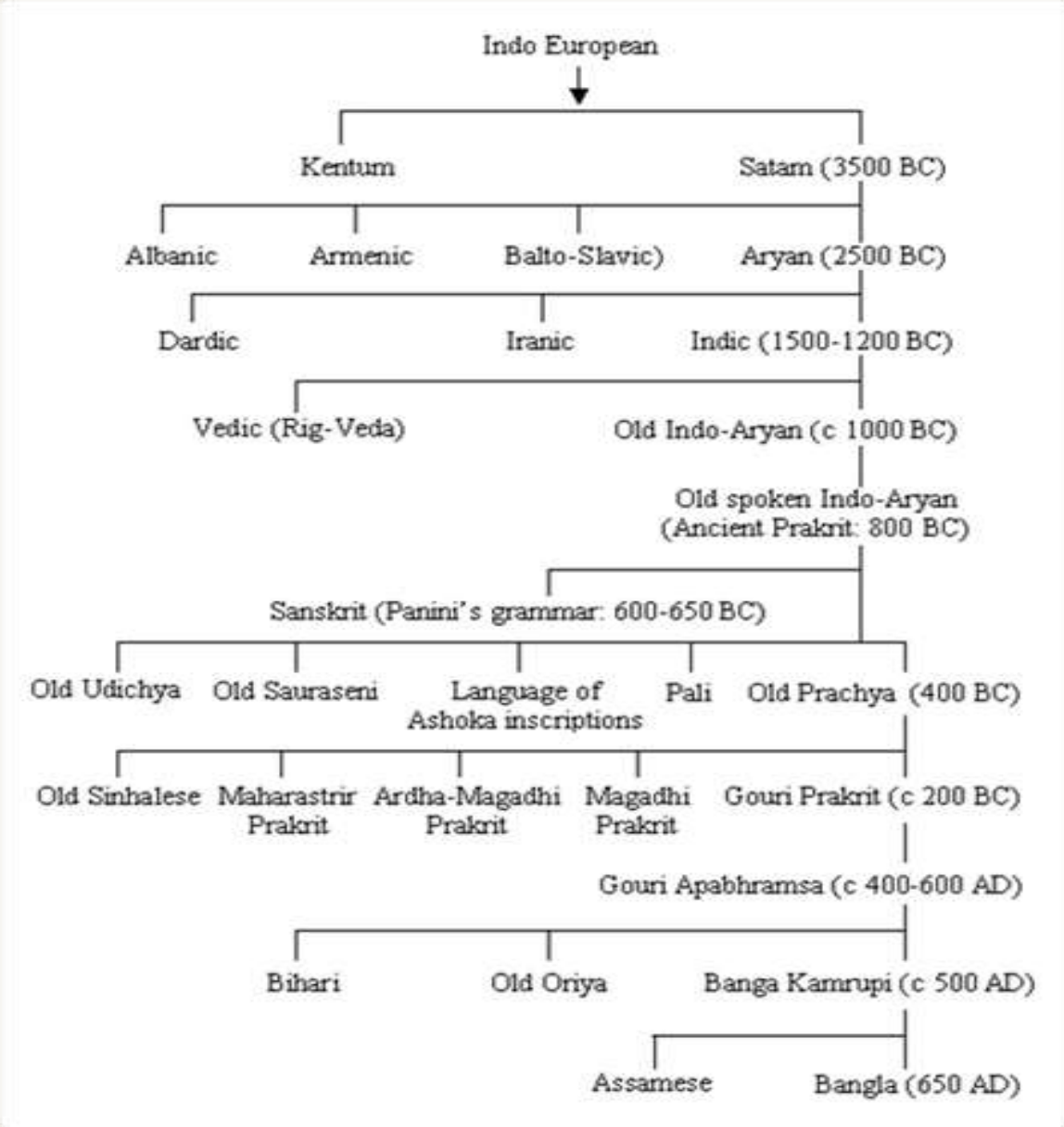
Bangladesh: Education

- Education in Bangladesh is highly funded by the Government, which operates many schools and colleges in the primary, secondary, and higher secondary levels, as well as many public universities.
- The whole country is divided into nine regional education boards (Dhaka, Chittagong, Rajshahi, Jessore, Barishal, Sylhet, Dinajpur, Mymensingh, and Comilla Education Boards), which oversee education from the primary to the higher secondary level, and conduct the primary and junior scholarship examinations, the Secondary School Certificate examination, and the Higher Secondary Certificate examination.

- To promote literacy among women, education is free up to the higher secondary level for female students. There is also a Government-funded program that gives incentives like stipends and food for continuing education at the secondary level.
- The education system is not unified as there are general education, Madrasah, English medium, and English version.
- There are 56 Public Universities and 115 Private Universities in Bangladesh.

Source: http://www.ugc-universities.gov.bd/

Bangladeshi Culture



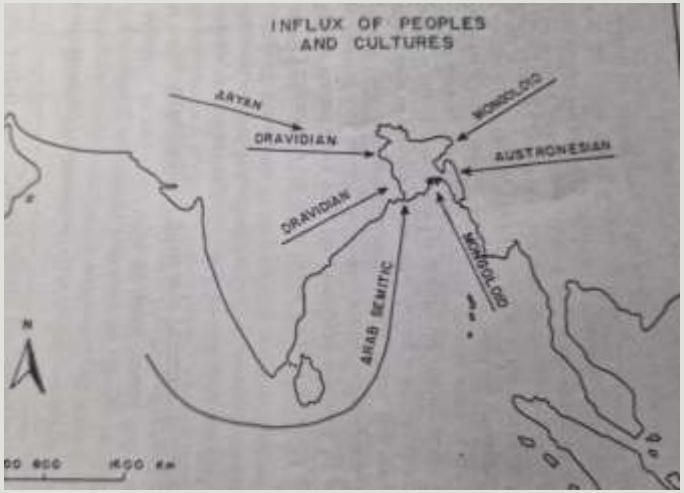
Bangladeshi Culture

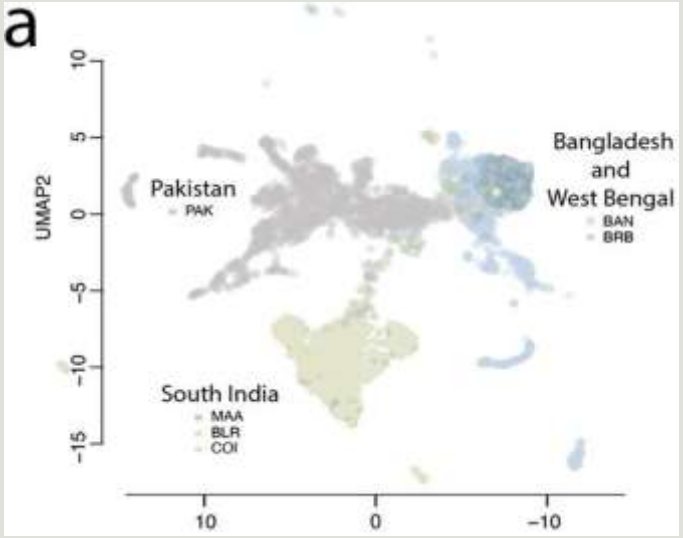
- Bangladesh is a melting pot of races and civilizations, resulting in a distinctive but mixed Bengali culture.
- The vast majority speak Bangla or Bengali, an Indo-Aryan language, written in Bengali script. It is the official language, though English is accepted in official tasks and in (higher) education.
- A small number of people, mostly non-Bengali Muslims from regions of India such as Bihar, speak Urdu. However, almost all non-Bengali Bangladeshis speak Bangla as a second language.

- Deep-rooted heritage is amply reflected in Bangladeshi architecture, literature, dance, drama, music, and painting.
- Bengali culture is influenced by three great religions-Hinduism, Buddhism and Islam in successive order, with Islam having the most pervading and lasting impact.
- Like a colorful montage, the cultural tradition of the country is a happy blending of many variants, unique in diversity but in essence greatly symmetrical.

For more about culture see: https://en.banglapedia.org/index.php?title=Bangali_Culture For more about language: https://en.banglapedia.org/index.php?title=Tribal_Languages

BANGLADESH: LAND & PEOPLE





Bangladesh: A Melting Pot

- **Austric- speakers** – (Cambodia, Myanmar)- Several thousand years
- **Mongoloids** – (Burmese and Thai) – around the same time or somewhat after Dravidians (South & West of SA), mostly cacuside Aryans (Northern Part of ME & Eastern Parts of Europe) around 1200 BC
- **Turks & Pathans**

Evidence

- Languages, Mythology
- Food habits, agricultural tools
- Physical features, hair, eye color etc.
- Genetic features/mapping

Pic: Genetic ancestry of South Asians (Indians) linking Austroasiatic migration in Bangladesh

Questions to Ponder

- What do you understand by “demographic dividend” and what are its positive or negative effects?
- Do you think that Bangladesh is a “melting pot” of ancient races/civilizations?
- What does the geographical reality of Bangladesh tell you about its connectivity with the region and the world?
- What does the history of Bengal tell you about the nature of its people, about their **aspiration for independent identity and self-determination**? Explain with one example from each period (ancient, medieval, and modern).

Thank you